

Establishing Rule Governed Behavior

In Applied Behavior Analysis (ABA), establishing rule-governed behavior means teaching a client to follow verbal or written instructions, known as “rules,” instead of relying on direct experience with consequences. This ability is crucial for safety and independence, as it allows individuals to learn complex or dangerous skills without having to experience the outcome firsthand.

A key concept is the distinction between

governed & contingency-shaped behavior.

Feature	Rule-Governed Behavior	Contingency-Shaped Behavior
Control	Behavior is controlled by verbal or written rules, such as “If you want to stay safe, then look both ways before you cross the street’.	Behavior is shaped and controlled by direct, immediate consequences in the environment.
Learning Process	Individuals learn by following instructions and don’t need to directly experience the outcome. A person who has never gotten a speeding ticket still drives the speed limit because of the rule.	Learning occurs through trial and error, where the consequences of an action directly affect future behavior. A person who has gotten a speeding before may now always drive the speed limit.
Key Advantage	Allows for rapid learning of complex skills and avoidance of dangerous consequences.	The resulting behavior is highly sensitive to changes in the environment, as it is based on real-time feedback.

Several strategies to help clients develop rule-following skills.

Break down instructions

Break complex tasks into small, manageable steps. A rule like “Clean your room” can be broken into “Pick up toys,” “Put clothes in the hamper,” and “Make the bed”. When making a rule regarding inappropriate conduct, state the rule using positive terminology (example “sit like a lady with your hands to yourself” rather than “no touching others” or “Help the coach stay safe when driving” rather than “don’t touch the coach when they are driving”). The simpler the person, the more direct the rule.

Use visual supports

Visual learners benefit from tools that make rules more concrete and understandable.

- Visual schedules lay out the steps of a routine, like getting ready in the morning.
- Contingency maps visually represent “if-then” relationships and the consequences of following or not following a rule. This is the Premack Principle.
- Social stories use pictures and simple language to explain social situations and rules.

Practice with reinforcement and modeling

- Reinforce success: Offer praise or rewards when the client successfully follows a rule to increase motivation. This can be a

token economy system or specific praise like, "Great job waiting your turn!".

- Model behavior: Therapists and caregivers can model the desired behavior to show the client how to follow the rule in practice.
- Fade prompts: Therapists may initially use prompts to help initiate the behavior, then gradually fade them as the client becomes more independent.

Generalize across environments

Use natural environment teaching (NET) to ensure that skills learned in one setting carry over to other settings, like at work, in the car, while in the community.

Challenges and considerations

- Rule insensitivity: An overreliance on rules can sometimes make an individual insensitive to changing contingencies, following an outdated rule even when it's no longer effective.
- Complexity: Some individuals, particularly those with more limited verbal skills, may not acquire rule-governed behavior easily, and specific procedures may need to be tailored to their needs.
- Consistency: For rules to be effective, they must be delivered with clear and consistent language. Without consistent follow-through, the client may learn that instructions don't always need to be followed.

A variety of challenges can complicate the establishment of rule-governed behavior, especially for individuals with conditions like autism spectrum disorder (ASD) or certain behavioral disorders. These challenges include verbal and cognitive difficulties, competing environmental contingencies, motivational issues, and the risk of rule-based insensitivity.

Cognitive and verbal challenges

Rule-governed behavior requires a certain level of verbal and cognitive skill, and deficits in these areas can hinder the process.

- Difficulty understanding abstract rules: A rule is a verbal description of an action and its consequences. If a learner struggles with language comprehension, they may not grasp the abstract nature of a rule, such as "be polite". Instead, they may require more concrete, specific instructions, like "say 'excuse me'".
- Prompt dependency: Some learners may become overly dependent on prompts and fail to develop independent rule-following. A prompt-dependent learner might wait for a cue before following a rule, even if they have the skill to do it on their own.
- Problems with verbal rehearsal: Many people silently repeat rules to themselves to guide their behavior. Individuals who do not engage in this self-talk may have a harder time using rules to manage their actions.

Insensitivity to changing contingencies

One of the most significant challenges is that overreliance on rules can cause a learner to become insensitive to the actual consequences in the environment.

- Rigidity and inflexibility: When rules dictate behavior, a person might become so rigid that they have difficulty adapting to a change in circumstances. For example, a student who is told to "always raise your hand" might not speak up during a group activity, even when the teacher has given the group a different, more flexible instruction.
- Psychological inflexibility: A strong tendency to rigidly adhere to internal, self-imposed rules can be linked to psychological suffering. For example, a person with a fear of gaining weight might follow rigid dietary rules despite the severe negative health effects.

Competing contingencies

A learner may fail to follow a rule if other, more powerful environmental contingencies push them toward a different behavior.

- Conflict between long-term and immediate consequences: A rule often describes a consequence that is delayed or improbable ("studying now will lead to a good grade later"). However, the immediate reward of engaging in a preferred, rule-breaking activity (like playing video games) can be a more powerful motivator.

- Social reinforcement: For many people, the approval or disapproval of others is a powerful motivator. A learner might break a rule to gain peer acceptance, even if they know the rule is important.

Motivational and contextual factors

Several other variables can influence how well a person responds to rules.

- Emotional regulation issues: For individuals with challenges in emotional regulation, overwhelming emotions like anxiety, frustration, or excitement can make it difficult to follow instructions.
- Lack of belief in the rule: A person is more likely to follow a rule if they have a history of reinforcement for following instructions and perceive the person giving the rule as reliable. If they have had experiences where rules were inconsistent or unreliable, they may not believe the described contingency will actually happen.
- Environmental inconsistency: A lack of consistency in rule enforcement across settings or individuals can make it difficult for a person to learn rule-governed behavior. For example, if a child is told not to run inside at school but is allowed to do so at home, they may become confused.